

## Teachers as Communicators of Ethical Values in Higher Education: An Evaluation of Lecturers' Perspectives in Nigeria

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### Abstract

This study examined lecturers' perspectives on the communication of ethical values in higher education institutions in Nigeria, focusing on Edo State University, Iyamho and the Federal Polytechnic Auchi. Using a mixed-methods approach that combined quantitative and qualitative data, the study explored the extent, types, and challenges of communicating ethical values in classroom settings. Data were collected from 100 lecturers using questionnaires containing both open and closed-ended questions. Some of the findings reveal that 51.11% of university lecturers and 48.89% of polytechnic lecturers communicate ethical values, with male lecturers (65.31%) being more active in this regard than females (26.53%). Hard work (90%) was the most frequently communicated ethical value, while proper eating habits (10%) were the least discussed. The study identified key motivations for teaching ethical values, including the need to instil moral principles, guide conduct, address curricular gaps, and reduce moral decadence among students. Conversely, a minority (8%) of lecturers did not integrate ethical discussions, citing irrelevance or strict adherence to academic content. The findings underscore the importance of educators as moral agents and role models in shaping students' ethical behaviour and character, aligning with the Transposition Theory that supports the transfer of learned values across contexts. The study concludes that ethical education in Nigerian higher institutions is indispensable for moral rejuvenation and recommends structured inclusion of ethical education in higher education curricula.

**Keywords:** Ethical values, higher education, lecturers, Nigeria, moral education, communication, Transposition Theory.

### Introduction

Students spend an average of six and a half hours daily with educators, where adults leave impressions on their lives. Thus, educators have a great responsibility to impart ethical or moral values in the lives of young people (Smith, 2017; Egielewa, 2020). Ethical values are understood as "standards that help an individual choose between right and wrong or good and bad." These ethical values help students or young people to make honest, credible, and fair decisions as they relate to the relationships in their daily life (Orchid Admin, 2021; Egielewa & Adejumo, 2021). Many students come to school with some values acquired from their families, many of which educators need to build on or even reinforce in the classroom. Some of those ethical values brought from home include kindness, self-discipline, honesty, and compassion, which educators build in the classroom (Smith, 2017; Orchid Admin, 2021; Egielewa & Adejumo, 2021). These family ethical values are enforced by teachers and educators. This view was re-echoed by Martin Luther King, Jr. in his 1947 paper "The Purpose of Education," published in the Morehouse College (Atlanta, Georgia) campus newspaper, the Maroon Tiger, and states thus (Smith, 2017):

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We must remember that intelligence is not enough. Intelligence plus character—that is the goal of true education. The broad education will, therefore, transmit to one not only the accumulated knowledge of the race but also the accumulated experience of social living. If we are not careful, our colleges will produce a group of close-minded, unscientific, illogical propagandists, consumed with immoral acts. Be careful, “brethren!” Be careful, teachers!

In the classroom, there are several ethical values that students don't learn at home, which educators impart to them in the course of their studies, particularly in the classroom. This is because young people and students in particular learn better by observing their environment, such as the classroom (Orchid Admin, 2021). In other words, teachers are involved in "using our classrooms to create environments that model positive value systems. In addition to values learnt from home, some of the more general ethical values include kindness, responsibility, honesty, empathy, compassion, self-discipline, open-mindedness, patience, the willingness to compromise and the ability to accept diversity (Smith, 2017).

Educators have more dynamic roles to play because students come from different ethnic and cultural backgrounds with different religious and social orientations, which condition their ethical values. Educators stand at the middle point in young people's lives to help them achieve the golden mean and create a balance that seems to accommodate the various contexts and cultural situations of the students. The classroom, therefore, becomes the pivot to bring all the divergences into harmony. This harmony between what ethical values students bring from home and what they learn from their educators is captured thus (Smith, 2017):

What that means is while the ultimate goal of educators is to nourish the minds of young children, we are also responsible for equipping them for society, which starts with teaching and enforcing positive value systems in our classroom communities. It starts at home, but it finishes with us.

There have been arguments that ethical values were the exclusive preserve of the family and the religious organisations, but increasing evidence has shown that both institutions are grossly inadequate to inculcate the right values needed for young people to grow responsibly, which are also considered universal. Thus, educators became an important channel to carry out these tasks. Such values that educators needed to impart in the classrooms included those six identified at the Meeting in Aspen, Colorado, on July 22-25, 1992, namely trustworthiness, respect, responsibility, justice & fairness, caring, and civic virtue and citizenship (Akin et al., 1995). Gökçe (2021) expanded these values to twenty, namely “virtue, respectfulness, affection, conformity, sympathy, patriotism, humanism, equality, justice, tolerance, responsibility, democracy, modernism, devotion, diligence, freedom, discipline, entrepreneurship, friendship, and cooperation” (p.7).

However, many scholars (Lashley & Barron, 2006; Shein & Chiou, 2011; Brady, 2011; Egielewa, 2022) have argued that teachers act as role models in the classroom from whom students learn. This increases the values society places on teachers, particularly within the confines of the classrooms and in some cases beyond.

A study by Gui et al. (2020) revealed that teachers should help students to foster their self-regulation, self-efficacy and self-development through the values imparted in the classrooms. In a similar study by Sari (2013) carried out on teachers in Indonesia in 2013, findings reveal

that teachers favour the teaching of ethical values. Also, based on data obtained from three focus groups with teachers from Bosnia & Herzegovina and Serbia concerning value teaching to students, findings from a study by Panti and Wubbels (2012), teachers generally agree that "teachers should exemplify proper models of behaviour at all times and teachers should wear decent dress" (p.11).

However, these studies cover studies in secondary schools and not higher education, and none examines teachers' perspectives of ethical values in the classroom from the point of view of Nigerian teachers, and none examined this from the perspective of higher education in Nigeria. The present study intends to close these two gaps. Thus, the study sets out to answer the following research questions.

1. To what extent do educators in higher education communicate ethical values to their students in the classroom?
2. What kinds of ethical values do educators in higher education communicate ethical values to their students in the classroom?
3. What kinds of reasons prevent educators in higher education from communicating ethical values to their students in the classroom?

## **Literature Review**

### **Educators and Moral Values**

Scholars have thought of educators as the moral compasses of society because of the important roles they play in the classroom, where they impart ethical values to young minds and generations who will eventually shape the future (Smith, 2017; Egielewa et al., 2024). Daniel (1996) calls this kind of setting the "critical-moral classroom", which he defines as

...a place where morals and virtues are debated, modelled, rethought and renewed every day and which depends on the teacher maintaining a critical-moral vision and demonstrating that vision in the way he or she teaches, interacts, answers and listens. The critical-moral classroom depends on the teacher's historically noted moral voice.

Educators reinforce ethical values in students in six major ways (Smith, 2017):

#### **1. Communicate ethical values clearly and effectively**

For ethical values to be carried out and reinforced amongst young people, they need to be communicated in unambiguous language, in terms that the students can understand and interpret. Only clear information is positively and effectively implementable.

#### **2. Follow the ethical values taught**

Educators do a lot of teaching, both academic, moral and ethical. However, students learn by doing. Educators should also put into practice the ethical values they try to inculcate into young students, particularly those of honesty, humility, responsibility, and compassion.

#### **3. Share lived ethical experiences**

Educators should not just teach students moral and ethical values and practice the ethical values; they should also share positive real-life experiences with the students. Shared experiences have a powerful way of influencing young people to adopt and follow the same.

#### **4. Help students practice learnt ethical values**

Students should not only be taught and exposed to real-life experiences of ethical values, but they should also be given practical ways of practising ethical values in the classroom. They should be told, for example, ways to be humble by talking politely to others, how to help people in need or avoid bragging or boasting about their good deeds, helping when there is a clear need for it, even when not asked, etc.

#### **5. Acknowledge good behaviour**

Positive ethical behaviour should be rewarded appropriately. This is not necessarily a physical gift but a word of commendation that will reinforce positive ethical values in others. A further step could be to inform the student's family, who could then transform such acknowledgement into a physical gift and by so doing reinforce these values in others, siblings and non-siblings.

#### **6. Intelligent use of media**

Media content impacts students. Ethical values must also include the responsible use of media content, including content on the internet. Due to students' and young people's ubiquitous exposure to media content, educators need to identify positive ethical values online and help students identify and discard harmful habits available for free online. Educators can analyse the dangers of certain media content, e.g. watching a YouTube video and collectively analysing the positive and negative impact of such a video on the responsibility and ethical maturity of the students.

#### **Theoretical Framework: Theory of Transposition**

The theory of transposition was advocated by Gestalt psychology, propounded by Wolfgang Köhler (1887–1967). It holds that skills, knowledge, and or attitudes that were learned in one situation are transferred to another learning situation, which could be a school setting as a classroom. However, such learning only takes place if there is a similarity of fact, process, principles and perception of the learners involved. In other words, there has to be some level of the established form of relationship between participants (Baroja, 2014; Reber & Reber, 1985).

In other words, Transposition Theory refers to the transfer of learning that is learned in one situation but which can be shifted directly to another situation and other persons, that is to say, generalizations, concepts or insights which are developed in one learning situation are employed as a whole in other situation and to persons in which they are applicable (Baroja, 2014; Reber & Reber, 1985).

This theory fits this study because teachers learn values in a different context, such as family, school or even religious environment and seek to transfer those same values to their students in the classroom. Transfer of learning, including ethical values, is one of the most important ideas in teaching and learning because teachers help their students to learn to make effective future use of what is taught and learnt (Baroja, 2014; Reber & Reber, 1985).

#### **Methodology**

The study employs the mixed research method that combines both the quantitative and qualitative approaches to understanding the problem this study seeks to interrogate (Fischler, 2020).

The study population is the academic staff of two institutions in Edo State, purposively selected, namely Edo State University, Iyamho and Federal Polytechnic Auchi. Although the total population of academic staff in both institutions are approximately 2000, the study deployed 50 questionnaires each to lecturers of Edo State University, Iyamho and Federal Polytechnic Auchi while they were in their offices between 10<sup>th</sup> and 31<sup>st</sup> January 2022, totalling 100 questionnaires retrieved for the analysis. The questionnaire contained 7 closed-ended and 2 open-ended questions.

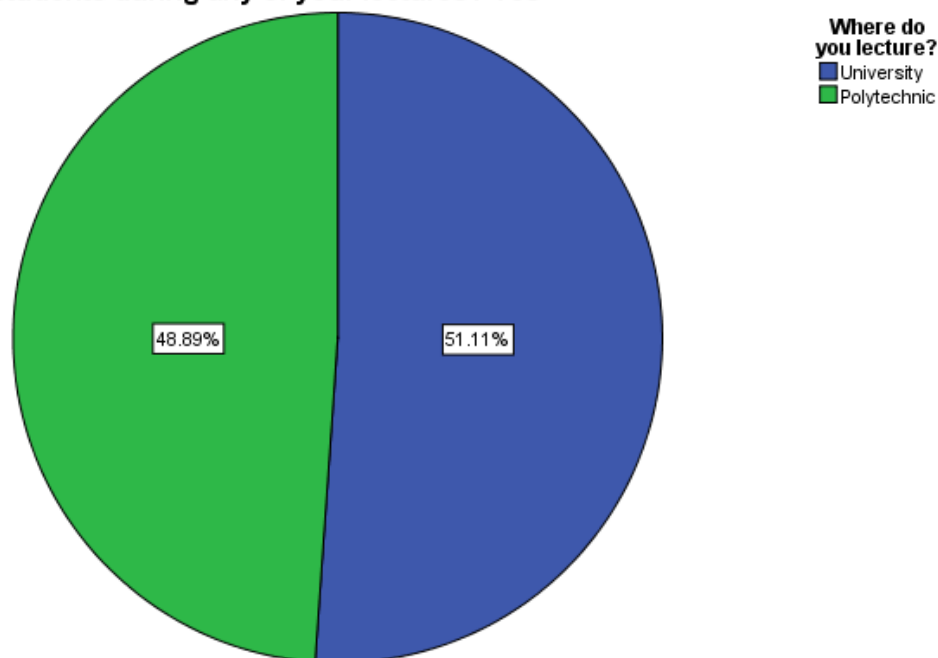
In the quantitative aspects of the study, data were collected and analysed using the Statistical Package for Social Sciences (SPSS), while the qualitative aspects analysed the subjective and personalised opinions of respondents from broad perspectives based on certain general concepts and terms (Fischler, 2020). The Data for the mixed research method were collected together using the questionnaire.

### **Presentation of Results**

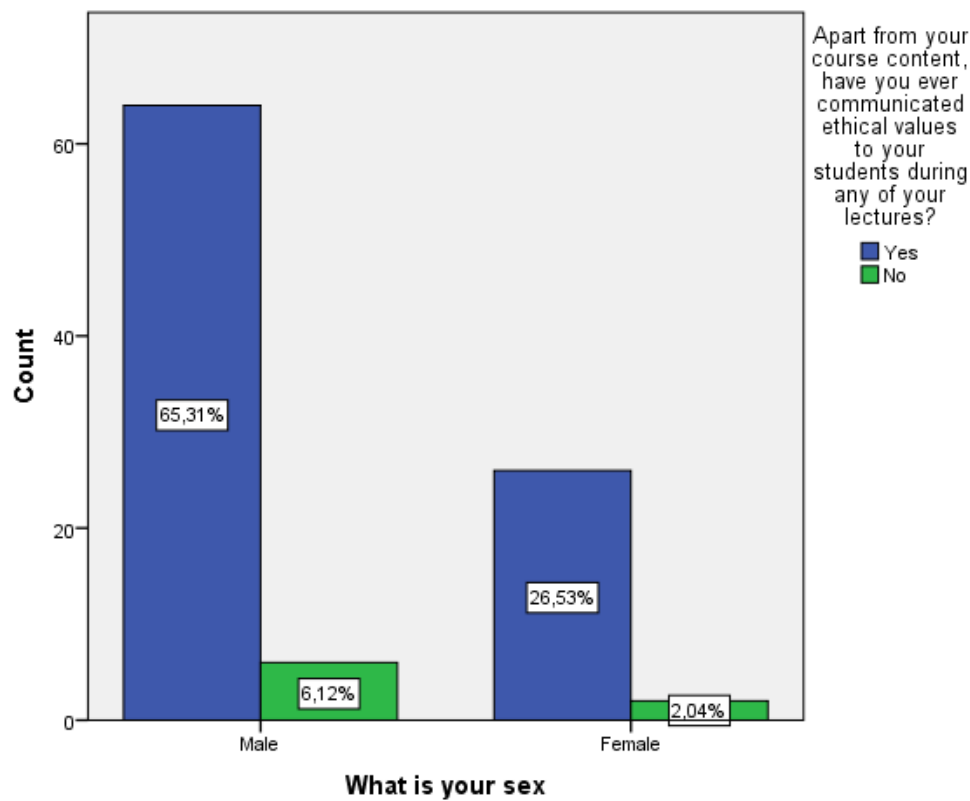
The data from the study is presented in charts and analysis as shown below.

**RQ 1: To what extent do educators in higher education in Nigeria communicate ethical values to their students in the classroom?**

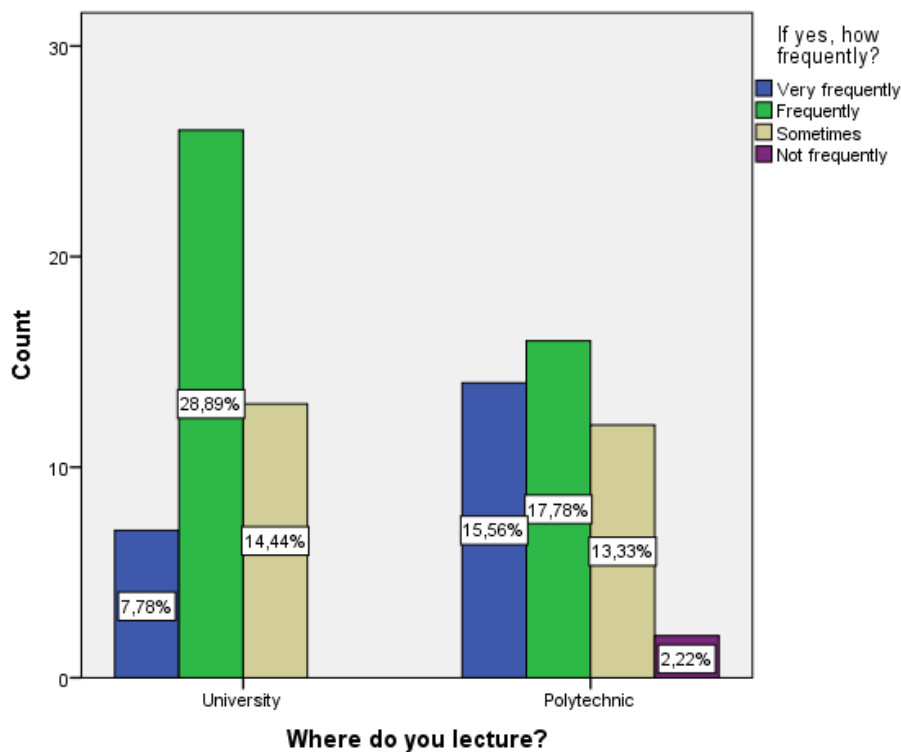
**Apart from your course content, have you ever communicated ethical values to your students during any of your lectures? Yes**



**Figure 1:** Frequency of communication of ethical values to Nigerian students based on the type of higher institutions.



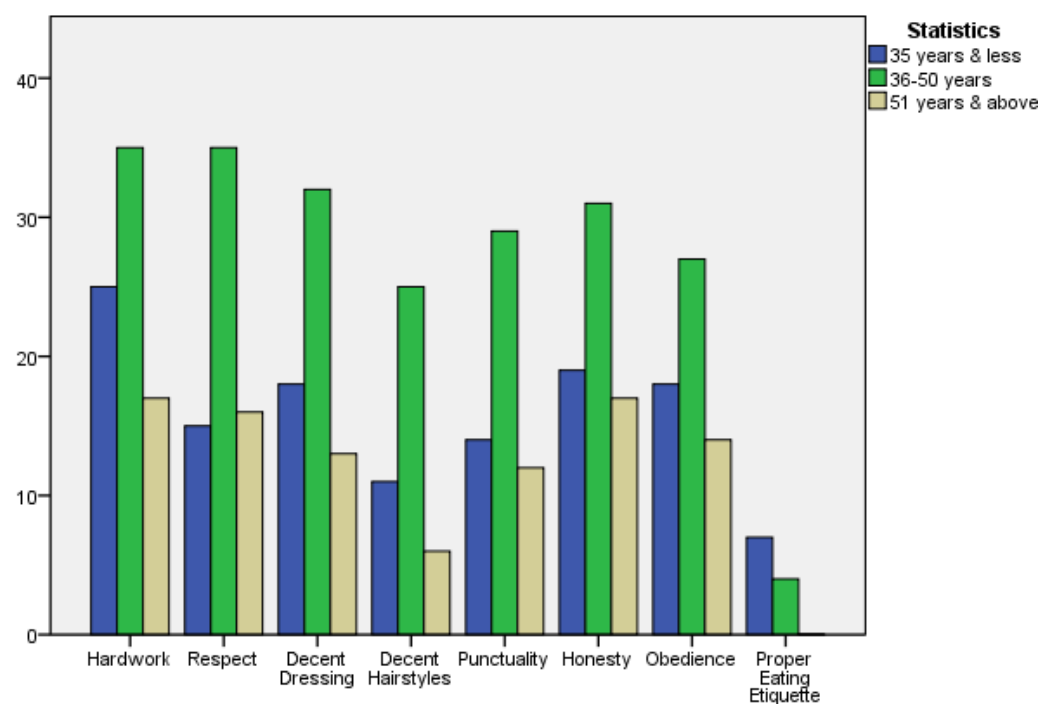
**Figure 2:** Frequency of communication of ethical values to Nigerian students based on the gender of the lecturers



**Figure 3:** Extent of frequency of communication of ethical values to Nigerian students based on the type of higher institutions.

Data in Figure 1 shows that more University lecturers (51.11%) communicate ethical values in the classroom than their Polytechnic counterparts (48.89%), although the difference seems insignificant. From the perspective of gender, Figure 2 shows that more male lecturers (65.31%) communicated ethical values than their female counterparts (26.53%). This implies that of every 3 lecturers who communicate ethical values during their lectures, two are likely to be male. In terms of the extent of frequency of communicating ethical values in the classroom, Figure 3 shows that university lecturers (37%) communicate ethical values more frequently than their Polytechnic lecturers (33%). This data confirms the finding in Figure 1, which shows that more university lecturers communicate ethical values in their lectures than Polytechnic lecturers.

**RQ 2: What kinds of ethical values do educators in higher education in Nigeria communicate to their students in the classroom?**



**Figure 4:** Types of ethical values communicated to Nigerian students based on the age of the lecturers.

Data from Figure 4 shows that middle-aged lecturers (48%, n=223) communicated ethical values to their students in their classroom compared to younger (27%, n=125) and older lecturers (25%, n=114). Thus, approximately 2 out of every 4 lecturers who communicated ethical values during their lectures are likely to be those within the age range of 36 to 50 years. In addition, data from Figure 4 shows that hard work (90%, n=78) was the ethical value that most lecturers communicated the most, while proper eating habits (10%, n=9) was the least ethical value they communicated.

Also, based on the findings from respondents, the reasons for communicating ethical values to students during their lectures can be grouped into five clusters:

1. To educate and instil moral principles in students
2. To guide their conduct
3. Due to the absence of the teaching of ethical values in schools
4. Due to the importance of ethical values
5. To reduce moral decadence among students

### **1. To educate and instil moral principles in students**

26% of the lecturers (n=26) posit that they undertake the teaching of moral values during their lectures to educate and instil moral principles in the students, as reflected in some of the responses. This implies that 1 in every 4 lecturers in higher institutions in Nigeria believe that they must help bring the students up, not just academically, but also morally.

Respondent 12: **“Because they have to know what ethical value means”**

Respondent 33: **“To make them know the rules and regulations of ethical behaviour that govern every profession”**

Respondent 41: **“To educate my students about the world after the present school they are currently”**

### **2. To guide the students' conduct**

25% of the lecturers (n=25) opine that they teach ethical values during their lectures to guide the conduct of their students, as demonstrated in some of their responses. This implies that every 4 lecturers in higher education in Nigeria see themselves not only as teachers but also as parents of their students and see it as their moral duty to help them develop good moral conduct as they grow to become adults in society.

Respondent 3: **“Because aside from the normal job as teachers, we are like parents to the students and need to guide them morally”**

Respondent 22: **“To guide them in their quest to become responsible citizens”**

Respondent 98: **“To help them grow in the right way”**

### **3. Due to the absence of the teaching of ethical values in schools**

18% of the lecturers (n=18) say that they decided to teach ethical values to their students during their classroom lectures because they feel that there are no lectures or opportunities in the school curriculum that cater for the teaching of ethical values to the students. In other words, approximately 1 in every 5 lecturers in Nigerian higher education because there are no ethical/moral lessons for students and therefore, lecturers should take this responsibility upon themselves, as the following responses show:

Respondent 1: **“As a result of an obvious lack of ethical values amongst most students”**

Respondent 54: **“Because no school curriculum teaches students ethical values”**

Respondent 60: **“Because our schools don't care about ethical values”**

### **4. Because of the importance of ethical values**

36% of the lecturers (n=36) opine that they undertake the teaching of ethical values during their lectures because of the importance of ethical values. That is to say, approximately 2 out of every 5 lecturers are ready to teach ethical values in their lectures because of their importance to students, as their responses demonstrate.

Respondent 13: **“Because it is important to impart other values on students so they can be good people in society”**

Respondent 20: **“It is necessary for a student to have ethical values as it is part of learning and teaches them how to cope and live in a society”**

Respondent 87: **“Because of the need to instil core salient values in the students”**

### 5. To reduce moral decadence among students

33% of the lecturers (n=33) say that they teach ethical values during their lectures because of the moral decadence they observe among students of higher education. In other words, 1 out of every 3 lecturers will willingly begin to teach ethical values during their lectures because they feel the students are morally deficient and need to be taught the right ethical values, as some of their responses indicate:

Respondent 4: **“Because moral decadence is on the rise, it prompted me to teach ethical values in my classes”**

Respondent 75: **“Because some students dress indecently and their manner of response when corrected politely”**

Respondent 100: **“To reduce the height of moral decadence”**

#### **RQ 3: What reasons prevent educators in higher education in Nigeria from communicating ethical values to their students in the classroom?**

Based on the findings of this study, respondents who didn't communicate ethical values during their lectures adduce justification for their positions. From Figure 2, 8% of the respondents (male and female) agreed that they do not communicate ethical values during their lectures. Some of such responses are given below:

Respondent 6: **“Because I think it is not important”**

Respondent 44: **“I only concentrate on my course content during my lecture and don't delve into other issues”**

Respondent 59: **“Because I am in the computer department”**

### **Discussion of Findings**

The study's findings affirm that educators play a vital role in transmitting ethical values within higher education in Nigeria, consistent with Smith (2017) and Egielewa and Adejumo (2021), who argue that teachers are moral agents whose influence extends beyond academics. The relatively balanced distribution between university (51.11%) and polytechnic (48.89%) lecturers communicating ethical values demonstrates a shared awareness of the moral responsibilities educators hold, irrespective of institutional type. This suggests that both academic settings recognise the declining moral standards among students and the need to integrate moral education within the learning process (Akin et al., 1995; Gökçe, 2021).

The higher participation of male lecturers (65.31%) in communicating ethical values compared to their female counterparts (26.53%) may reflect existing gender dynamics within Nigerian academia, where male lecturers often dominate classroom interactions. This finding aligns with Sari (2013), who reported that teachers' personal orientations influence their moral teaching engagement, suggesting the need to focus efforts on promoting gender-balanced involvement in moral pedagogy to contribute to the holistic development of students.

Regarding the types of ethical values communicated, the predominance of hard work (90%) as a central theme reflects a pragmatic orientation among lecturers. In a context where academic dishonesty, absenteeism, and examination malpractices are common (Egielewa, 2022; Egielewa & Adejumo, 2021), emphasising diligence reinforces societal expectations of personal effort and responsibility. The least emphasised value—proper eating habits (10%)—

reveals that lecturers prioritise cognitive and character-based ethics over lifestyle-related guidance. This finding supports Daniels' (1996) notion of the "critical-moral classroom," where teachers prioritise virtues central to responsible citizenship.

Middle-aged lecturers (36–50 years) emerged as the most active in ethical communication (48%). Their professional maturity and life experience likely position them to better integrate moral instruction into pedagogy, supporting Reber and Reber's (1985) argument that value transfer depends on experiential learning. The Transposition Theory underpins this dynamic by suggesting that educators transfer learned moral values from prior contexts—family, religion, or society—into classroom interactions (Baroja, 2014).

The motivations behind communicating ethical values reveal educators' recognition of moral decay within Nigerian higher education. A significant proportion (36%) teach ethical values because of their perceived importance to student formation, while 33% aim to combat moral decadence, corroborating Gui et al. (2020), who emphasised that teachers shape students' self-regulation and ethical self-development. Similarly, 26% teach ethics to instil moral principles, and 25% do so to guide student conduct. These motivations reflect teachers' internalised sense of social responsibility and align with Panti and Wubbels' (2012) assertion that teachers should model ethical behaviour and decency.

The 18% of respondents who introduced ethical instruction due to the absence of a formal ethics curriculum highlight an institutional gap in moral education. Their actions compensate for structural deficiencies in Nigeria's tertiary curricula, which traditionally prioritise technical and professional competencies over ethical formation. This aligns with Orchid Admin (2021) and Egielewa et al (2024), who stress that ethical education is critical for nurturing well-rounded individuals and leaving moral education to the discretion of lecturers would lead to inconsistencies in content, frequency, and delivery.

A notable minority (8%) of lecturers abstained from ethical instruction, arguing that it was irrelevant or outside their disciplinary scope. This position illustrates a compartmentalised view of education that separates moral from intellectual development, contradicting Martin Luther King Jr.'s 1947 (Smith, 2017) assertion that "intelligence plus character" defines true education. Furthermore, the study's findings underscore the role of educators as models of ethical conduct. As Brady (2011) and Shein and Chiou (2011) emphasise, students learn not only through direct instruction but by observing teachers' behaviour, suggesting that educators need to embody the ethical standards they teach, as hypocrisy in moral instruction undermines credibility. The inclusion of experiential sharing and recognition of good behaviour, as suggested by Smith (2017), can enhance student engagement with moral concepts, making ethics instruction practical and relatable.

In summary, this study substantiates that Nigerian higher education lecturers actively communicate ethical values, motivated by societal concerns and personal convictions. However, gender disparities, curricular limitations, and differing perceptions of relevance impede uniform implementation. Institutionalising ethics education through policy, curriculum integration, and professional development will ensure that moral instruction becomes an intentional and structured part of teaching and learning.

**Conclusion**

This study concludes that lecturers in Nigerian higher education are pivotal agents in the transmission of ethical values, bridging the moral gaps left by family and religious institutions. The findings show that while most educators actively communicate moral principles such as hard work, honesty, and responsibility, their efforts are largely personal and unsystematic. Gender disparities, institutional differences, and curriculum deficiencies continue to hinder a coherent approach to ethics education. The application of the Transposition Theory affirms that lecturers' personal moral foundations shape their teaching practices, reinforcing the transfer of values from one context to another. Ultimately, the study reveals that moral education is not merely supplementary to academic instruction but integral to developing balanced, responsible citizens. For ethical communication to be effective, universities and polytechnics must recognise and formalise the moral dimension of education. Structured policies and training programmes are required to help educators systematically and effectively embed ethical discourse in their classrooms, ensuring that higher education contributes meaningfully to the moral renewal of Nigerian society.

**Recommendations**

Based on the outcome of this study, the following are recommended:

1. Nigerian higher institutions should incorporate ethical education into general studies and departmental syllabi to institutionalise moral instruction.
2. Periodic ethics training and workshops should be organised for lecturers to enhance their moral communication skills.
3. Universities and polytechnics should establish policies mandating ethical engagement in all academic interactions.
4. Educators should consciously exemplify the ethical standards they teach to reinforce credibility.
5. Students should be encouraged to participate in peer-led ethical discussions and rewarded for positive behaviour to sustain value-based learning environments.

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